

Group Discussion

- "Discussion is an exchange of knowledge; argument is an exchange of ignorance"
— Robert Quillen quotes
- "Having a good discussion is like having riches."
— Kenyan Proverb quotes
- Never doubt that a small group of thoughtful, committed citizens can change the world. Indeed, it is the only thing that ever has.
— Margaret Mead
- The leader can never close the gap between himself and the group. If he does, he is no longer what he must be. He must walk a tightrope between the consent he must win and the control he must exert.
— Vince Lombardi
- Democracy means government by discussion, but it is only effective if you can stop people talking.
— Clement Atlee

Case Study

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THE IMPORTANCE OF GROUP DISCUSSION IN INTERVIEWS

(Sumit Bhattacharjee)

The Hindu Education Plus (E-Plus) Club hosted a workshop on group discussion and personal interview in association with TIME- Vizag at Pydah College of Engineering and Technology, Visakhapatnam, at the college campus on Monday. The workshop was open to all the E-Plus club members.

Elucidating the importance of group discussion, the Director of TIME J. V. Murthy, said, "Group discussions has become an integral part of the selection process. It is being used as a selection tool, not only by B-schools but also by core and software companies."

Defining GROUP DISCUSSION, he said, "GROUP DISCUSSION is a forum where people sit together to discuss a topic with the common objective of finding a solution for a problem or an issue that is given. GROUP DISCUSSION is conducted to measure certain attributes in a candidate such as content, communication skills, group behaviour and leadership skills."

He pointed out that content plays the most important role in a GROUP DISCUSSION. "One should have a good understanding of the given issue or topic. And by reading a good

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newspaper he or she can improve the content. During the GROUP DISCUSSION process, it is imperative to develop or enhance the content by listening to the other speakers. A healthy content should comprise a few 'for' points and a few 'against' points," he said.

Doling out a few tips he said: Avoid long sentences and redundant ideas. Be innovative as far as possible and avoid using high-sounding words and verbose sentences. Pack your part of discussion with examples and analogies. Mr. Murthy also gave an insight into various approaches to a GROUP DISCUSSION session. E-plus club members enthusiastically participated in a mock GROUP DISCUSSION session. The mock session was organised by Sumit Bhattacharjee in Visakhapatnam. Asish Chowdary of TIME.

10.1. MEANING OF GROUP DISCUSSION

Meaning of Group Discussion. It is a form of organized and determined oral process, distinguished by the formal and structured exchange of views.

Group discussion is a judgemental procedure. In this procedure, the candidates are divided into small groups. Then they have to exchange their views on some issue situations.

It is for the most part utilized for selecting contender for the most part utilized for selecting contender for administration posts. Here, the candidates are divided into small groups. Every gathering contains six to eight hopefuls. Every gathering gives a point for discussion. They are additionally given a period limit for examining this subject.

The theme of the topic may be a General, Current Point, Social, Management, Sports, Creativity, General Interest, Politics, Economics or Education.

For example

1. Is WhatsApp killing mind ?
2. What are the Advantages and Disadvantages of Mobile Wallet ?
3. Are Leaders born or they are made in Business Schools ?
4. Should Group Discussion (GD) be part of Campus Placements ?
5. Is E-Learning an appropriate substitute of Classroom Learning ?
6. Should public smoking not be banned ?
7. Devalued Yuan – Effect on Indian and World Economy ?
8. Is media a mixed blessing ?
9. Are harsh punishments more effective in reducing crime ?
10. MBA helps you succeed in life ?

Group discussion is mostly unstructured. That is, every single step is not planned in advance. Each candidate is not given a time limit for speaking. Similarly the order of speaking, that is who will speak first and who will speak last is not fixed in advance. The candidates have to decide how to conduct the group discussion. The selectors see how the group takes shape, and who contributes most to it. They also judge the knowledge of each candidate, time management, leadership quality, behavior etc.

10.1.1. Characteristics of Group Discussions

1. **Team up.** A basic feature of Group discussion is the integration among the various members of the group. Active listening and effective communication should be there.
2. **Members and leader.** In the group one should be a leader and members. The leader should lead the discussion and interact the whole group members with each other.
3. **Effective participation.** Effective and active participation of the members must be there.
4. **Positive appeal.** It is a totally interpersonal appeal. Everyone has to develop empathy and try to share each others problems.
5. **Adaptation.** It is mandatory. The predefined and standards are always applied and followed.

10.1.2. How to Initiate, Lead and Conclude a Group Discussion (GD)?

Initiating, leading and concluding a Group Discussion is essential techniques to get noticed and earn golden points in a Group Discussion.

Group Discussion is an essential part of B-School selection process. A Group Discussion is conducted to test various managerial skills such as communication, leadership, rational, analytical, interpersonal, etc. There are many ways in which you can make your performance impressive and effective in a Group Discussion.

How do you ensure that the panelists notice you during a Group Discussion? Initiating a Group Discussion is a great move towards grabbing the attention of the panelists. But be careful of what you speak while beginning a Group Discussion, as that may make or break your chances of getting through to the Personal Interview round. Once the topic is announced, take a moment to absorb the topic of Group Discussion and start by saying something relevant to the topic. Then initiate the Group Discussion as most of your fellow members would probably be trying to understand the topic too.

During a GD, you need to take up different and important task roles to make the Group Discussion more effective and productive. These task roles in a Group Discussion can be positive as well as negative. You should avoid taking up negative task roles in a Group Discussion.

10.1.3. Positive Task Roles in a Group Discussion

1. **Initiator** - Starting a Group Discussion, giving definitions and suggesting and introducing new ideas.
2. **Information seeker** - In a Group Discussion, gather and solicit information from others.
3. **Information giver** - During Group Discussion share information and facts.
4. **Procedure facilitator** - Lead a Group Discussion by keeping track of the discussion.
5. **Opinion seeker** - Ask other participants of a Group Discussion for their opinion.
6. **Opinion giver** - Give your opinion in a Group Discussion on the statement given by the other participant.
7. **Clarifier** - Clarifying all the ideas and opinions discussed during a Group Discussion.
8. **Social Supporter** - Giving support to ideas of all participants of a Group Discussion.

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9. **Tension Reliever** - Presenting and discussing the problem on broad prospective.
10. **Energizer** - Encouraging other participants to explore some new ideas during a Group Discussion.
11. **Compromiser** - Creating harmony between different opinions by giving the compromising solution.
12. **Gatekeeper** - Involving other participants in the Group Discussion by asking for their opinion.
13. **Summarizer** - Summarizing or concluding a Group Discussion by including all important points discussed during a Group Discussion.

10.1.4. Negative Task Roles in a Group Discussion :

1. **Disgruntled non-participant** - Someone who doesn't contribute to the Group Discussion.
2. **Attacker** - Someone who aggressively disapproves opinion of other participants of a Group Discussion.
3. **Dominator** - Someone who takes control of the discussion and not letting others speak in a Group Discussion.
4. **Clown** - Someone who does not take Group Discussion seriously and disrupts it through inappropriate humour.

10.1.5. How and Why to Initiate a Group Discussion?

1. By beginning a Group Discussion, you not only hold an opportunity to speak, but also you grab everybody's attention.
2. By initiating a Group Discussion you will get maximum nonstop time to present your views and skills to the examiner as other participants are still busy in understanding the topic.
3. Try to make an impression through your content and communication skills while beginning a Group Discussion.
4. Stay courteous and appeal humble during a Group Discussion. It's important to address other participants and for people names used in your topic using salutation Ms., Mr., Honorable, His / Her Excellency etc.. as applicable.
5. While initiating a Group Discussion, you should not stammer or quote wrong facts.
6. You should initiate a Group Discussion only if you have properly understood the topic and have some knowledge about it.
7. Try to give right direction to a Group Discussion by giving logical points.
8. If you are beginning a Group Discussion, try to cover all the relevant points and present them clearly.
9. Initiate a Group Discussion by giving a quote, definition, facts, figures and statistics, shocking statement with logical questions, short story or general statement

10. Do not take much time after beginning a Group Discussion as it will give an impression that you initiated a Group Discussion for the sake of just starting it

10.1.6. How to Enter a Group Discussion midway?

If you have not initiated the Group Discussion, don't lose heart. You can still enter the GD and make your presence felt.

1. Identify a way to enter a Group Discussion, as every Group Discussion has its highs and lows. Try to enter a Group Discussion during low times.
2. Try to enter the Group Discussion after a participant has made his point but do not take much time.
3. Try to enter a Group Discussion by making a supportive or appreciating ^ statement in favour of the last point made as people will think you are favouring them and they will let you speak.
4. It takes great talent to speak sense continuously and hold everyone's attention. Once you have made a breakthrough in the Group Discussion try to steer the conversation or discussion towards a goal or some sort of conclusion.

10.1.7. How to Lead or Carry on a Group Discussion?

1. Try to bring new ideas in a Group Discussion.
2. You can creatively modify ideas presented by others and develop them during the Group Discussion.
3. Try to gain support from other participants of the Group Discussion through your — body language, eye contact and oral etiquette. This plays an important role for you leading the Group Discussion.
4. Find out if the Group Discussion is on track or not. If a Group Discussion is going off track, try to bring it back on the topic.

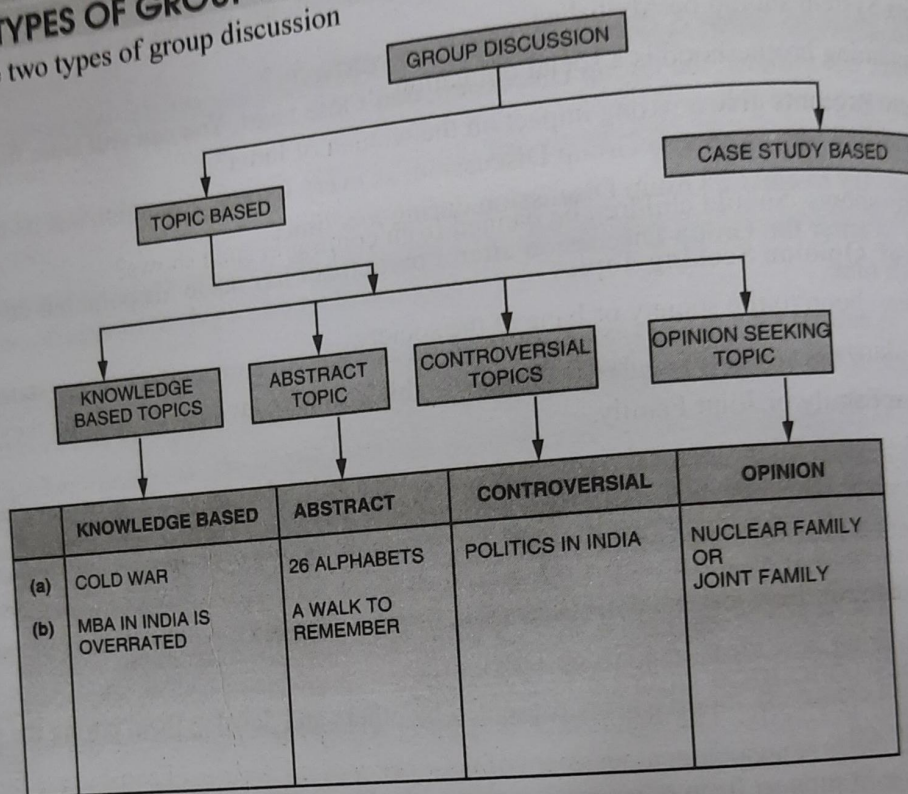
10.1.8. How to Conclude a Group Discussion?

This is your last chance to win golden points. Concluding a Group Discussion is as important as the beginning as it showcases your potential to integrate and evaluate before taking any discussion, which is a requisite of a successful manager.

1. You should summarise all points discussed in a Group Discussion in the nut shell.
2. While concluding a Group Discussion, avoid raising new points.
3. Do not the emphasis on your individual viewpoint while summarising a Group Discussion.
4. Keep the conclusion of a Group Discussion concise.
5. While summarising a Group Discussion, include all important points that came out during the Group Discussion.
6. Avoid emphasis on one aspect of the Group Discussion. If someone has concluded the Group Discussion, do not contradict unless the conclusion has appropriate.

10.2. TYPES OF GROUP DISCUSSION

There are two types of group discussion



Examples of Knowledge Based Topics

1. Unique Identification Number.
2. Cold War.
3. Is terrorism the price we have to pay for democracy?
4. Globalization and Privatization.
5. Is Mixed Economy preferred?
6. Privatization of Universities/colleges/schools.
7. Does India need a dictatorship?
8. MBA in India is overrated.

Examples of Abstract Topics

1. A Tear drop on my Guitar.
2. Where there's a will there's away.
3. 26 Alphabets.
4. Infinite Numbers.
5. A Walk to Remember.
6. Six Billion and One Gold.

Examples of Controversial Topics

1. Reservation should be removed.
2. Quota System should be Abolished.
3. Maintaining brotherhood is a social obligation.
4. Beauty Pageants give a wrong impact on the women of India.
5. Politics in India.
6. Reality shows- Should children be banned from coming in such shows?

Examples of Opinion Seeking Topics

1. Women - boon to the society or bane to the society.
2. Love Marriage or Arranged Marriage.
3. Nuclear Family or Joint Family.

10.3. IMPORTANCE OF POSITIVE BODY LANGUAGE

The Entire body acts as an instrument of speech, candidates must understand that it is not just the mouth that speaks. So, they must first understand how their body speaks and then learn to manage and control the non-verbal messages that they send across to their audience.

10.3.1. Body Language : Things to consider

1. **Shake hand perfectly.** The handshake is a court us way to acknowledge our all group members. It is the first unspoken assessment of your personality. A proper handshake is firm to the right extent. With a smile and good eye contact, it becomes a good one.
2. **Smile.** A smiling and happy face shows that you are really happy to be where you are. But, oversized and artificial smile can have the wrong effect, remember it.
3. **Be careful of personal space.** We must ensure that we respect the personal space that the candidate sit beside you when sitting in a group discussion.
4. **Be Expressive.** The negative physical gestures would not so well and should be strictly avoided. We must try to engage our team by gesturing positively. We should always avoid pointing fingers to make a point during the group discussion.
5. **Demonstrate curiosity.** The best way to show your eager in group discussion, maintain an eye contact and nodding our heads. It shows that we are actively engaged in the discussion and paying attention to what the others are saying. Lack of eye contact would suggest our disinterest and weaken our chances to succeed.

10.3.2. Body Language : Things we should avoid

1. **Showing nervousness.** We should control our nervousness. Some gestures such as tapping the fingers, biting or licking the lips, adjusting hair or clothing again and again must also be avoided. The judges are smarter and more experienced than you are, so they can easily perceive gestures that portray anxiety. So try to remain calm and relaxed and do not make unnecessary movements

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2. Getting too relaxed. Crossed feet, and completely stretched our legs, locating with our arms and legs dangling would suggest, we are getting too relaxed. It also indicates our over confidence. Therefore we should try to show some seriousness by becoming an active listener and effective speaker without making any negative gestures that undermine over intent and eagerness.

4. Becoming Defensive. It is advised not to cross our arms during the discussion processes. We should be receptive not defensive. Instead, sit upright with our arms rested on our thighs to cut our a confident picture.

Candidates should participate in the discussion in a favorable body language, it is not just about questions and their right answers. They should understand that portraying a positive body language is as important as speaking and performing well in the group discussion. Try to prove them that we are expressive.

10.4. IMPORTANCE OF GROUP DISCUSSION

1. It enhances your knowledge. In this way, the learning is shared and you are benefitted. This is not only to exchange your ideas with your team but also increase your knowledge. Group discussion is a good platform to learn more and more.

2. Discussion generates good questions. Different minds discussing the topic, generates good questions and try to find their answers. It generates others eagerness to find more and more.

3. It shows weakness. Until you don't know about your weakness, you cannot improve. In group discussion, you come to know that in which areas you have to work hard and to improve.

4. It retrieves your mistakes. It retrieved your mistakes. When you share it in discussion, you come to know that it is wrong. So, your wrong concepts are retrived otherwise you may write this wrong concept.

5. It helps you to "how to study and how to make preparation for the exam". During the group discussion, you have to meet many candidates. A close interaction, learn you a lot. You come to know about the latest pattern of preparing the exams.

6. Effective communicator. By participating in group discussion, you can become an effective communicator.

EXERCISE

1. Why group discussions are held? Describe different techniques used in organizational group discussions.
2. What is the main purpose of a group discussion?
3. Why should a G.D is highly structured?
4. Write short notes on nature and Importance of group discussion.
5. Is grappling a desirable trait in making decisions in a group? What signs would tell you of the presence of grouplink in a group discussion? How will you handle such a situation?